

RALPH TELLS A STORY



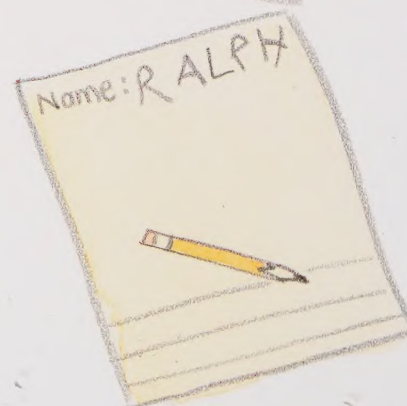
by Abby Hanlon

Nothing ever happens to Ralph.

So every day when it's time to write stories, Ralph thinks really hard. He stares at his paper. He stares at the ceiling.

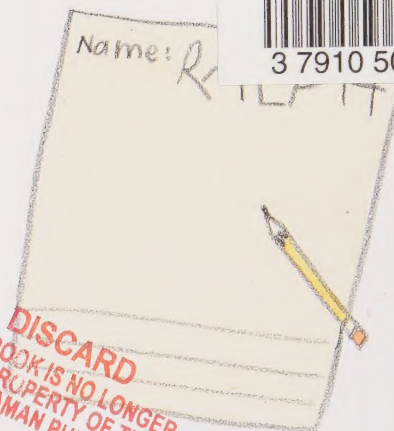
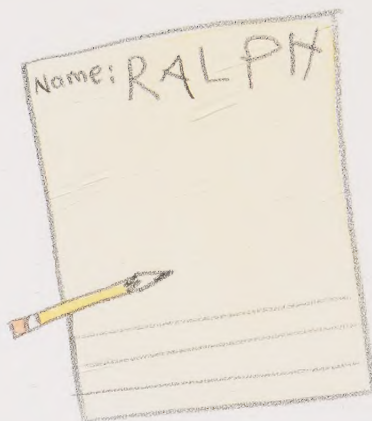
But he has no stories!

With the help of his classmates, Ralph realizes that a great story can be about something very small . . . and that maybe he really does have some stories to tell.

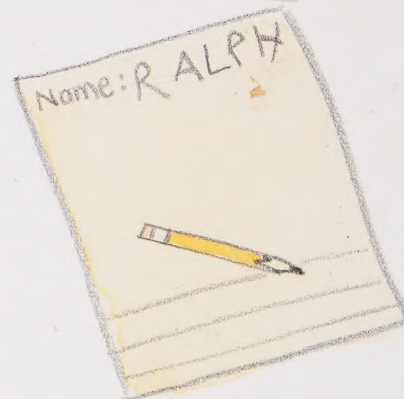
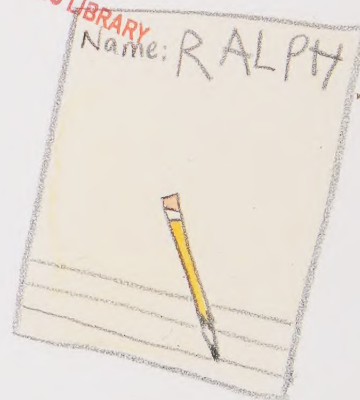




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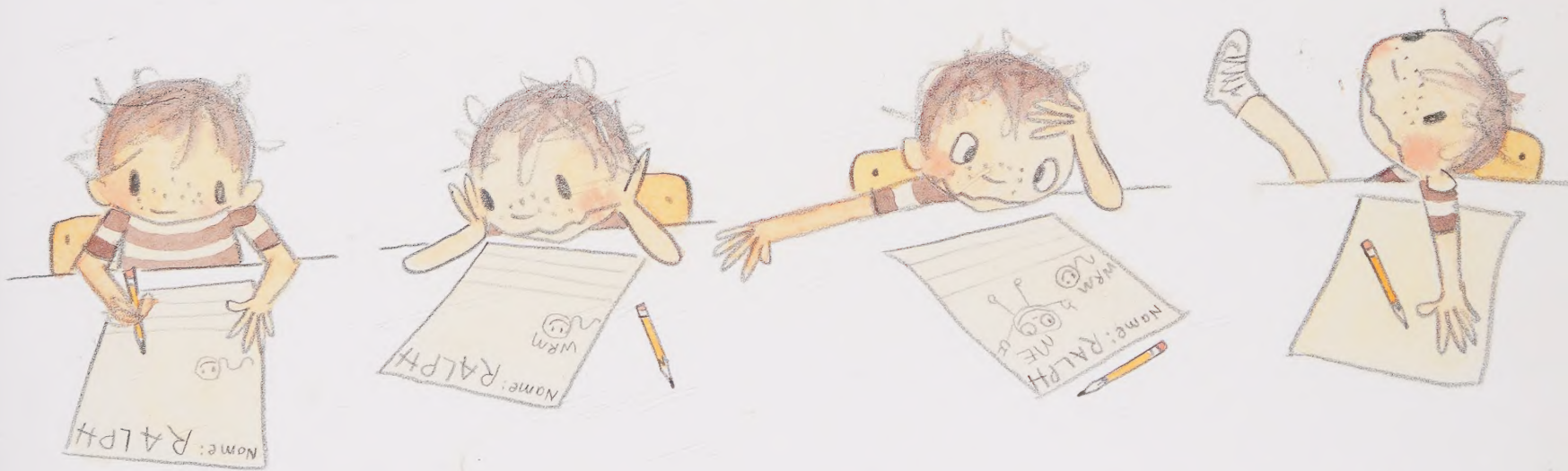
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Ralph Tells a Story

by Abby Hanlon



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Summary: Although his teacher insists there are stories everywhere, Ralph cannot think of any to write.

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For Lulu, Burke, and Nicky



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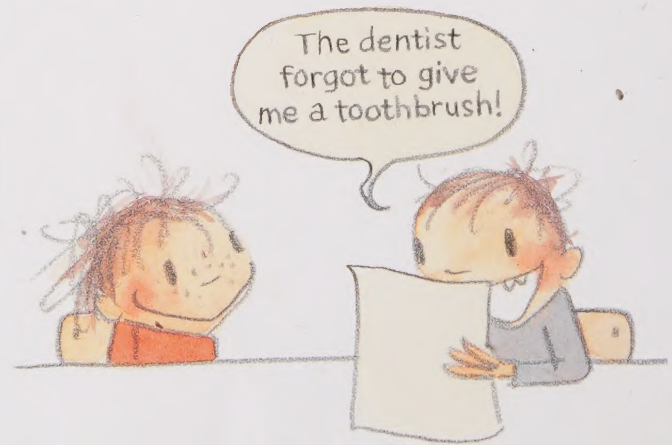
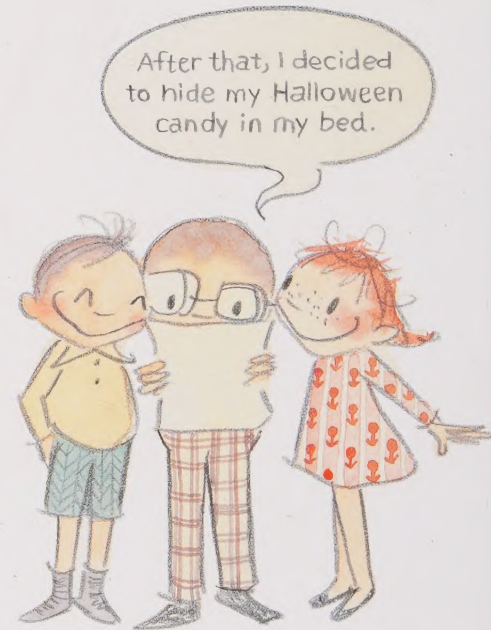
My teacher always said,

<https://archive.org/details/ralphtellsstory0000hanl>

“Stories are everywhere!”



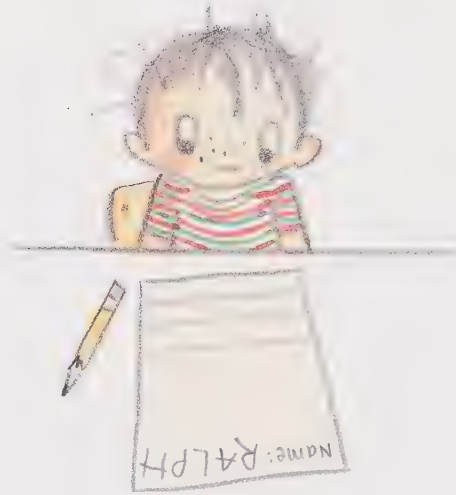
And the kids in my class were always finding them.



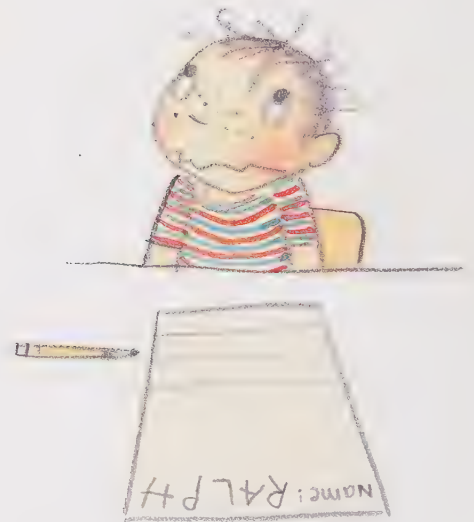
But every day at writing time,



I thought really hard.



I stared at my paper.



I stared at the ceiling.

I could not write a story.

Then Grandma gave
me a cup of coffee
and said, "Don't tell
your mother."



AAAAHHH!
I have no
story!

OUR FAVORITE CHARACTERS:



So I looked for other things to do.



I went to the water fountain.



I roamed the hallways.

I tried everything.



Then one day, after getting sent back to my desk, I begged Daisy for help. “I can’t write a story because **NOTHING** happens to me!”

“Are you kidding?” she said. “I’ve written a ton of stories about you!”

She began pulling her stories out of her desk. “Look at this one,” she said. “Remember the time you let me brush your hair? And this one! Remember the time you knocked down all the crayons? Oh and remember the time you painted your nails with a black marker?”



I thought, I'll never be a great writer like Daisy.

Then Daisy stapled all her stories together. *Click click!* “Wow!” she said. “This book is already thirteen pages!” *Click click!*



“Can I use the stapler?” I asked.
I was *really* good at stapling.
“But you have nothing to staple!” said Daisy. “You have to find a story first!”



So I looked for stories
out the window . . .



in the aquarium . . .



. . . in my desk.



And when my teacher wasn't looking,
I looked for stories on the floor.





But still no stories.



Lying under my desk reminded me of lying in the grass at the park.

I closed my eyes and imagined I was at the park . . . just like that time a little inchworm crawled on my knee. The sun was shining right into my eyes. Squinting, I picked up the wiggly inchworm and looked at it close-up.



And that's when my teacher found me. "What's your story about?" she asked.

I opened my eyes. "Um . . . um . . . I saw an inchworm."

"Wonderful!" she said. "I can't wait to read what you wrote."

But there was no inchworm story!



I sat down and tried to write about the inchworm, but right away I got stuck.



“Do you know any inchworm stories?” I asked Daisy. She just rolled her eyes and kept on writing.



And then my teacher said:



“Ralph, why don’t you go first?” said the teacher.
I pretended that I had lost my paper.



It didn't work.



I walked to the front of
the rug. It took a long time.



I held my paper against my
chest so no one could see it.

"I was at the park," I said.
"An inchworm crawled on
my knee."



It was quiet.



My heart went: *Thump. Thump. Thump. Thump.*



That's when I looked at Daisy.



And then everybody started asking me questions.



Wait a minute! I thought. SOMETHING DID HAPPEN WITH THAT INCHWORM!



Well, I picked up the
inchworm and decided
to name him Nick.



I built Nick a house
but he just inched
away.

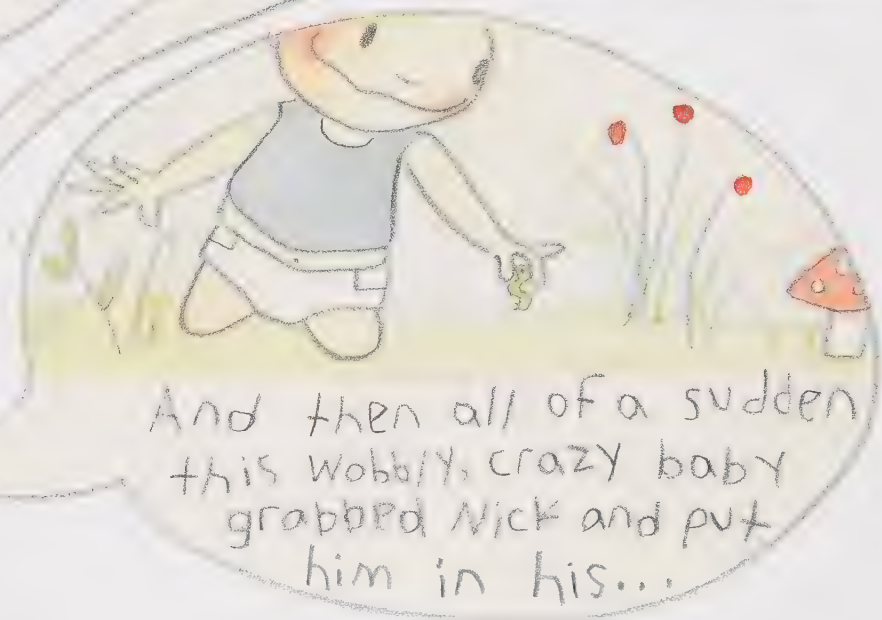




So I followed him...



Which is why I didn't notice that someone was following me.



And then all of a sudden this wobbly, crazy baby grabbed Nick and put him in his...



I tried to be calm.
"Come on, baby," I said
really nicely. "Give Ralphie
the inchworm." It didn't
work. Was this the
end of Nick?





But then I noticed...
Nick was escaping! He
crawled right up the
baby's stomach.



Quickly, I rescued Nick
and ran.



And we spent the rest
of the afternoon doing
nothing together.
The End.

Everybody clapped and cheered. "Show the picture, Ralph," someone said.



I wasn't embarrassed anymore so I did.



That was last year. This year I write stories all the time. I keep finding stories everywhere.



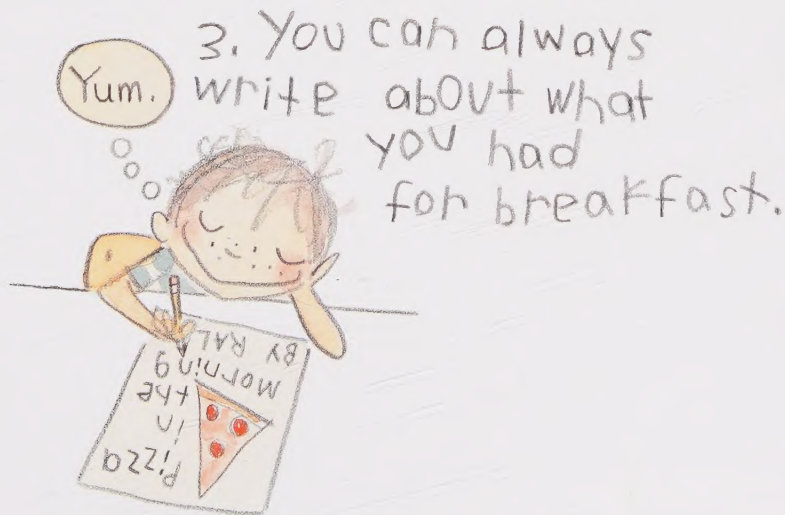
Writing Tips from Ralph



1. Get comfortable.



2. IT'S OKAY TO ask for help.

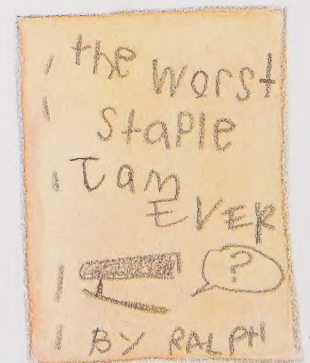
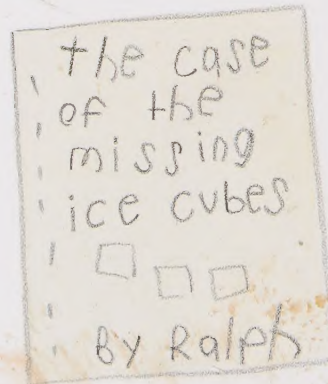
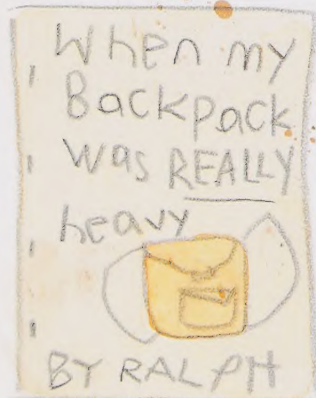
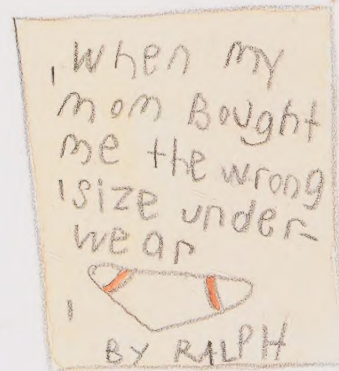
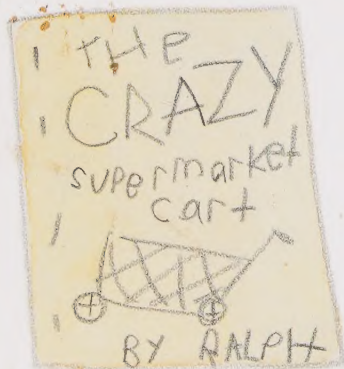
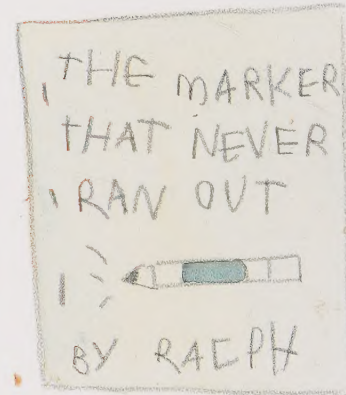
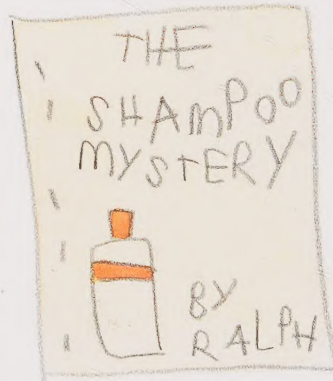


3. You can always write about what you had for breakfast.



4. Eat lots of chocolate.

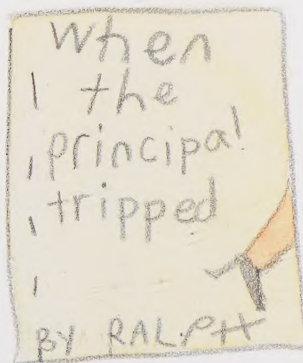
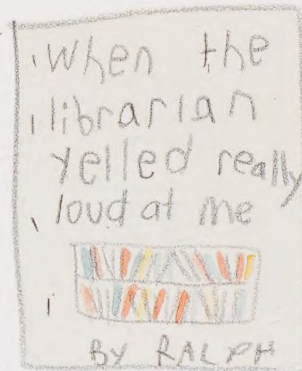
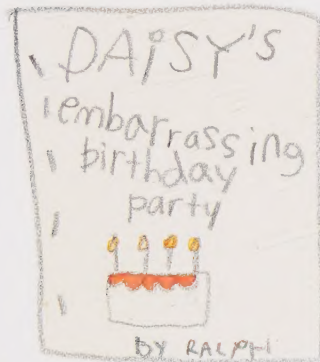
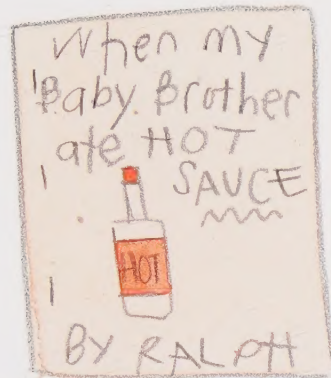
Books by Ralph



Abby Hanlon

has a master's degree in childhood education from the City College of New York and a bachelor's from Barnard College. Abby has taught creative writing and first grade in the New York City public school system. Inspired by her students' storytelling and drawings, Abby began to write her own stories for children. Determined to illustrate her stories, Abby taught herself to draw after not having drawn since childhood. *Ralph Tells a Story* is her first book.

Abby lives in Brooklyn, New York, with her husband and two children. Learn more about the author: www.abbyhanlon.com



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